An eternity seems to have passed since Parekh & Singh, the Kolkata-based dream-pop duo comprising Nischay Parekh (vocals, guitar) and Jivraj Singh (drums, electronics), released a full-length album. Their last album, the mesmerising *Science City*, came out in 2019; the acclaim was cut short when the duo cancelled their multi-city album tour, owing to Parekh's mental health struggles around live performances. "Perhaps I'm not supposed to be a live performer," Parekh, then 26, said on Instagram about logistical constraints triggering his anxiety issues. When the Covid-19 pandemic made the world retreat indoors in 2020, it afforded the musicians a stopgap of sorts. They could now recalibrate their vision and expand the possibilities of their own sound.

Three years since, the result is there to see in *The Night is Clear*, the duo's third full-length album that was released in September this year. Weaving together a diverse set of musical touches and eras, the album's nine tracks embody the band's penchant for creating an immersive sonic universe through visually suggestive lyrics, imaginative arrangements, and a distinct harmonic construction. It's an album that demands the same attention from listeners that it took from the two musicians to create it.

By Parekh's own admission, the band's ambition for *The Night is Clear* was to build a dense world, one that was inviting enough for anyone to listen to each song multiple times. "We have included a lot of elements in *The Night is Clear* and the idea was for all of these threads to have some amount of cohesion," he says.

Much of *The Night is Clear* was put together virtually—Parekh moved from Kolkata to Dubai during the pandemic, while Singh continues to work out of Kolkata. Singh believes the experiment was successful partly because the duo shares an unhurried approach to making music and an efficient working process. "We've been working at a distance in our home studios for the longest time, so the change in lifestyle [during the pandemic] didn't really affect our working life that much. I would say, it just focused us."

> ***The Night is Clear*** **is Parekh & Singh's third full-length album after the mesmerising** ***Science City***

Both Parekh and Singh describe themselves as musicians who are conscious about continuously working on their craft, an approach that they channelled into *The Night is Clear*, both in terms of the searing honesty and inventive quality of their compositions. "It's one thing to put music out and have a continuous dialogue with the audience. But the other dialogue is with ourselves and with each other as creators, as musicians, and as students of music. I think constantly raising the bar for ourselves has always been imperative to us, whether or not it translates for the audience," explains Parekh. For Singh, too, *The Night is Clear* feels like a marked progression in his personal movement as a musician.

Like the last time around, Parekh & Singh announced a two-month-long multi-city album tour after launching *The Night is Clear*. But this time, the pandemic has helped Parekh see the merit in live performances without it overwhelming him. "I think this is the first time I've actually started enjoying the process. I have started enjoying my time on stage, playing these songs, and connecting with our fans." ■

Poulomi Das



stream-of-consciousness lyricism lending it purpose and forward motion—in 'I'm Going Solo', he sings, "I'm going solo/ solo is the way to go" with an understated defiance, over the plucked strings of a guitar and a faint harmonica in the distance—and Rajani seems to favour warmth over flash for the most part. He mentions that Bob Dylan, Paul Simon and Mark Knopfler have been influential voices.

In addition to Rahul Ram, *Cutting Loose* is elevated by several other big names such as Rohan Ganguli (Supersonics), Abhay Sharma on the sax, bassist Ralph Pais and Susmit Bose. Rajani says Bose, who has done backing vocals here, is a friend and mentored him through the making of *Cutting Loose*. "The others, I just reached out to them. I said, 'Give it a listen, if you think it's worthy of your contribution, then add your bits.' They didn't go by my credentials, that I'm a debut artist ... They just went by the aesthetics. They liked what they heard," he says.

Rajani was clear from the beginning that he wanted to bring seasoned musicians into the album. And while their quality was no doubt the primary reason, Rajani acknowledges that their name lends credence to *Cutting Loose* as well. "It's very hard to sell an album when I'm not an established singer-songwriter already. It has to be done; it has to be a complete package. People are looking for familiarity," he says. Ultimately, though, *Cutting Loose* is Rajani's own creative vision imprinted onto the music. He describes his songwriting and composition process as existing in an altered state of mind. The act of creation itself, he feels, is honest, intuitive self-expression—"I don't think at all," he says. "The process is that there is no process." ■

Akhil Sood